Key Messages

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- **In January, household food access remained relatively stable compared to late 2025, supported by seasonal increases in income from average agricultural labor demand for coffee and sugarcane harvests, remaining household food stocks from an average *primera* harvest, and well-supplied markets.** Meanwhile, seasonal declines in staple grain prices have improved market access, despite prices remaining above last year and the five-year average. However, as cash crop harvests end between February and March, income will seasonally decline for poor rural households. Food stocks from own production are likely to be fully depleted by April, increasing very poor households' reliance on markets amid persistently elevated staple food prices. Most poor households are expected to be able to meet their minimum food needs through sustainable coping strategies, but a portion of very poor households – particularly smallholder farmers and agricultural laborers in the Dry Corridor – are expected to increasingly adopt negative coping strategies.

- **Seasonal agricultural labor opportunities continue to provide income for poor households through February when cash crop harvests conclude.** The anticipated average 2025/26 coffee harvest has helped sustain labor demand during peak harvest months, providing seasonal wages and supporting poor households in meeting food and non-food needs at the start of the year. While remittances continue to be an important income source for many households in El Salvador, inflows are expected to decline from last year's elevated levels, due to shifting policies in sending countries. As labor demand seasonally contracts in March and remittance inflows slow, declining income will increasingly constrain purchasing power through May.

- **Markets remain well supplied following near-average national maize production in the 2025 *primera* season,** replenishing household food stocks. However, above-average temperatures during the *postrera* season caused localized red bean losses, particularly in the Dry Corridor. While most households continue to rely on maize stocks, affected poor households have below-average red bean stocks and are increasing their reliance on markets atypically early. **Meanwhile, staple food prices – including maize and beans – declined seasonally between December 2025 and January 2026 but remain higher than last year and the five-year average.** Gasoline and diesel have remained stable through 2025; while this has contained transportation costs, above-average staple food